



BEFORE

In the spring of 1862, the Peninsula Campaign brought the Union Army of the Potomac to within striking distance of the Confederate capital, Richmond.

STUART'S RIDE

Appointed commander of the Confederate Army of Northern Virginia in June, Lee suspected that the **Union right flank was open to attack** and ordered cavalry commander, **Jeb Stuart**, to carry out reconnaissance. Between June 12–16, Stuart rode with 1,200 men in a **100-mile (160-km) circuit** around the Union Army, returning with the news that the flank was indeed unprotected **north of the Chickahominy River**.

LEE SUMMONS JACKSON

Lee ordered General "**Stonewall**" **Jackson** to move toward Richmond from the **Shenandoah Valley**, where his army was resting after a **highly successful but exhausting campaign**. Jackson arrived just in time to participate in Lee's offensive.

Lee's offensive began with a scare. With around 54,000 of his men committed to the attack, he had left minimal forces in the defensive lines in front of Richmond, counting on the cautious general, George McClellan, not to launch an assault. But on June 25, the day before the Confederate advance was scheduled to begin, Union forces probed the defenses at Oak Grove. To Lee's relief this turned out to be just a minor operation, although the skirmish it provoked has since been regarded as the first of the Seven Days Battles.

The Confederate offensive began on June 26, but neither on time nor as planned. Lee intended for the fighting to start in the morning, with General Jackson attacking the exposed corps on the Union right from the rear. Generals A. P. Hill, D. H. Hill, and James Longstreet would join in after Jackson. Inexplicably, however, Jackson did nothing, and in late afternoon, tired of waiting for him to make a move, A. P. Hill mounted an assault of his own against entrenched Northern troops at Beaver Dam Creek. The Confederates were repulsed with heavy casualties. McClellan's response to having won this tactical victory was to order his men to withdraw from the positions they had so determinedly held, to higher ground behind a swamp. Still convinced he would be assaulted by large numbers of Confederates, he also set about